EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Does God Have a Body?

Given Monday 24 June 2024 · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 2:8-10

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon **Essay/Chapters:** Essay 2, Chapter 8 (subtlety and strength; the principle of metaphor), Chapter 9 (the ten categories; substance and quantity) and the opening of Chapter 10 (the ten bodily descriptions) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 24 June 2024, on Zoom

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: The Story of Essay 2 So Far

Chapter	Content
1	The five things the prophets tell us about Hashem: one, living, omnipotent, omniscient, incomparable
2	Proofs that there can be only one deity, against the dualists
3	Verses that use both Hashem and Elohim, or otherwise seem to imply plurality
4	Hashem as living, omnipotent and omniscient, all in one, with **no diversity** in Him. It is wrong to think of Him as having distinct qualities
5	Philosophical arguments against the **Trinity**
6	Verses that seem to support the Trinity, and Rav Saadia's answers
7	The **four categories of Christian belief** about the Trinity in his day

Following up on last week, the Rabbi mentioned that someone had pointed out to him afterwards that the doctrine of the **Immaculate Conception** was only formally accepted by the Catholic Church in **1854**. It shows that over a thousand years ago, in Rav Saadia's time, there was still a wide diversity of opinion about what exactly the Trinity meant.

That completes the discussion of Yichud Hashem. For the rest of Essay 2, Rav Saadia turns to **anthropomorphism**: verses that seem to give HaKadosh Baruch Hu some physical essence. "He is the first rabbi we know of to address this head-on, directly."

Chapter 8, Part 1: Can the Most Subtle Be the Strongest?

Before he gets to anthropomorphism, Rav Saadia asks one more question. We have established that Hashem is the **most subtle of all**, with no diversity. But how can the most subtle also be **the strongest**?

Isn't that an oxymoron?

Look at reality, he says. Reality tells you that **the more subtle something is, the more powerful it is**:

Subtler	Coarser	Who is stronger?
The soul	The body	The soul directs the body
Wisdom	The soul	Wisdom is even more abstract, and it directs the soul in how to direct the body
Water	Earth	Earth is crass and material, water flows and is lighter, yet water seeps in and uproots the earth
Wind	Water	Wind is intangible, yet it moves the water
Fire	Wind	Fire is the strongest of all (he goes into some of the old science of fire)

This is why we find **wisdom** specifically attributed to HaKadosh Baruch Hu:

ה׳ בחכמה יסד ארץ Hashem founded the earth with wisdom. (Mishlei 3:19)

So Hashem's being the most subtle of all does not take away from His strength. On the contrary, the more subtle, the stronger.

Chapter 8, Part 2: The Foundational Principle

Now Rav Saadia turns to the question of physical descriptions, which will occupy several chapters. "Everyone after him really accepted this," the Rabbi said, then corrected himself:

"I'm not being precise there, because there were Rishonim, believe it or not. I know this is shocking. One of the **Ba'alei HaTosafot** writes explicitly that HaKadosh Baruch Hu has physical attributes. That's a very, very difficult concept to understand, but we have to reject that."

Rav Saadia will give convincing proofs, from Scripture, from logic and from tradition, that we cannot attribute any physical qualities to Hashem.

Substance and happening

He begins: we hear believers speaking about Hashem as if He listens to our prayers, hears us, sees everything we do. Let me first set out a principle:

Any hint of **substance** (an ear, an eye, a nose) or of **happening** ("Hashem came down to see Sodom", "Hashem stretched out His hand") is inappropriate to say of the Creator. Not a little inappropriate. It is false.

Why? We established in Essay 1 that the Creator created all physical things. There is no substance and no event in this universe that He did not create. It is ludicrous to describe Him with one of the things He Himself created.

Three points

1. **It is rationally impossible** to attribute any substance or happening to Hashem.

2. **All verses in Scripture** that seem to imply physical attributes must be given an explanation *zulat hagashmah*, other than the physical one, "until it sits well with our logic."
3. **When we speak with each other,** when rabbis and believers say "Hashem is listening" and so on, we are only **borrowing** the terms. There is absolutely no comparison to human properties.

Once these three points are clear, says Rav Saadia, do not be troubled by what you read. Everything that follows, in these chapters and in all of Scripture, is built on this foundational principle. "You build upwards from the bottom. You don't build from the top downwards." Whenever you find something in the Tanach that gives you doubts, follow this principle.

Why does the Torah speak this way at all?

The Rabbi raised a question Rav Saadia will address explicitly later: why use these expressions? Why give the impression that Hashem has an eye and an ear? Why not speak plainly?

A participant answered that it helps people understand, by giving examples from human life. "Very good," said the Rabbi, and added more:

"If we weren't able to use these expressions, we would have no words to talk about God."

He mentioned a group of **Muslim thinkers** who held that one could not speak about God in any of these terms. They were mocked and lost any ability to teach, "because they can never talk about Hashem." If you only allow purely spiritual terms, you have nothing to say except that He exists. Even the words "the way Hashem relates to us" imply some association. "So you end up with nothing."

A participant compared it to the Japanese koan: we know the sound of two hands clapping, but what is the sound of one hand? It is very hard to convey such things without human terms. "Nice analogy," said the Rabbi.

Chapter 9: The Ten Categories

Rav Saadia now lists **ten things** that the Tanach seems to attribute to Hashem, and will go through each:

#	Category	Example
1	**Substance**	That Hashem is made of something
2	**Quantity**	A certain height, length or width
3	**Quality**	
4	**Relation**	Friend of one, enemy of another: "I loved Yaakov, and Esav I hated"
5	**Place**	Verses about Hashem sitting on a throne
6	**Time**	As if Hashem were bound by time
7	**Possession**	Verses about Hashem owning something
8	**Position**	Hashem having a certain status relative to others
9	**Action**	Hashem acting
10	**Being acted upon**	Hashem as the recipient of action

He spends most of his time on the first three. "And again, this is foundational, because no one has done this before him. We're so used to it, but never forget that he's doing this for the first time." And of course he chose ten, "because he loves the number ten."

1. Substance

People debate what Hashem is "made of":

- Some say He is like a human, only a huge and very powerful one.
- Some say He is **fire**, from the verse **כי ה׳ אלהיך אש אכלה הוא**, "Hashem your God is a consuming fire" (Devarim 4:24), "which we read on Tisha b'Av". They picture a huge ball of fire.
- Some say He is air.
- Some say He is **space**. (The Rabbi noted that the Hebrew edition's word here, *kesef*, silver, is a mistranslation from the Arabic. It should be *space*: they believe He is one great space.)

Rav Saadia's answer: since He is the Creator of humans, of fire, of air, of space and of all existence, as established in Essay 1, logic tells you none of these can be part of His essence.

The five levels of existence

Rav Saadia shows the same from Scripture. There are **five levels of existence** (leaving humans aside), and for each the Tanach tells us not to compare Hashem to it. The Rabbi noted that **Rabbi Yehuda HaLevi does something similar in the Kuzari** about a century later.

Level	Verse
Inanimate: the most precious are gold and silver	To whom" :**למי תדמיוני ותשוו... הזלים זהב מכיס וכסף בקנה ישקלו** will you liken Me and make Me equal... those who pour gold from the purse and weigh silver on the scale" (Yeshayahu 46:5-6)
Vegetation: the most precious is the **cedar**, the tallest and most beautiful tree, to which the righteous are compared	Yeshayahu's mockery of the idol carved from a tree: neither the image nor the cedar is comparable to Him
Animals	The Torah's warning not to make an image of any animal, bird, creeping thing or fish (Devarim 4)
Stars	"To whom will you liken Me? Lift up your eyes on high and see who created these" (Yeshayahu 40:25-26)
Angels	Who in the heavens can be compared to" :**כי מי בשחק יערך לה׳** Hashem?" (Tehillim 89:7)

On the double expression in Yeshayahu ("to whom will you liken Me, and make Me equal"), Rav Saadia explains it works both ways: nothing is comparable to Hashem, and Hashem is not comparable to anything.

These verses gather together all five levels of existence and push us away from comparing Hashem to any of them. "This should be your foundation" whenever you meet a problematic verse.

"In the Image of God"

Now Rav Saadia faces one of the most difficult verses in the Torah:

> God created man in His image, in the image of **ויברא אלהים את האדם בצלמו, בצלם אלהים ברא אותו** God He created him. (Bereishit 1:27)

The Rabbi asked the class how they had always understood it.

Flora suggested it means that just as Hashem is full of mercy and kindness, we should follow His ways, though she noted this is difficult since we have been told His *middot* are not really describable. She added Tehillim 8: **ותחסרהו מעט מאלהים**, "You have made him a little less than the divine."

The Rabbi gave **the classical approach**: *tzelem* means we have, as it were, the same **power** as God. Not identical, but the same kind of ability. Just as HaKadosh Baruch Hu creates and can destroy, we can create and destroy, physically and spiritually. When we do the right thing we create spiritual worlds. When we do the wrong thing we destroy them.

Rav Saadia's reading

Rav Saadia takes *tzelem* to mean a **physical** form. "And to be honest, he's right," the Rabbi said, "because *tzelem* normally has the connotation of something physical." In modern Hebrew, *letzalem* means to take a photograph.

Rav Saadia: This is simply an expression of **honour and distinction** for the human being. All lands belong to Hashem, yet He says "My land": **עיני ה׳ אלהיך בה**, "the eyes of Hashem your God are always on it"

(Devarim 11:12). Does He own this land more? No, it signifies special importance. All mountains belong to Hashem, yet He says "My mountain." All forms of all creatures, fish, animals and birds, are His, and He distinguished one of them by calling it "My form."

So according to Rav Saadia, the form is physical, but "My form" means "**this is My favourite form of all the forms I have created**," not "I have a form too."

A lively debate

Chaim found it weak: "It's very general, and it's not convincing, to me at least." He suggested that something in our form and construction lets us act almost on the level of God, giving the human power to go beyond himself. The Rabbi said that is the approach of the **Nefesh HaChaim**, from about 200 years ago, and is quite acceptable, but it means *tzelem* is entirely spiritual. Rav Saadia wanted to keep the word's physical meaning.

The Rabbi offered an illustration of Rav Saadia's point: "If I have a class of students and I really like one of them, I'll say 'this is my child'." Chaim objected that the Torah is extremely precise, and if it meant "this is Mine," it would have said so. The Rabbi replied that every interpretation here involves some assumption. Another participant noted that idols are also called *tzelamim* because they are formed things, and wondered how one can be made "in the form" of One who has no form.

A participant offered her own simple approach: Hashem has no form at all. "Tzelem" means we should do as Hashem tells us in the Torah, which He wrote before creating the world. "I don't know if it's too simple." The Rabbi said it was an absolutely fine explanation, and that she and Chaim were really saying the same thing: that we are godly. "But just remember, you take away the simple meaning of *tzelem*." Rav Saadia, who is very precise about verses, would not do that, so he keeps *tzelem* physical and reads the possessive as love and distinction.

"A consuming fire"

What about **אש אכלה**? Does it mean Hashem *is* fire? No: He is **like** a consuming fire to those who deny Him. Scripture often drops the letter **כ**, "like":

Verse	Meaning
ויוצא אתכם מכור הברזל ממצרים: "He took you out of the iron furnace, out of Egypt" (Devarim 4:20)	Egypt was not literally an iron crucible. It means *as if* from a crucible
David to Shaul: **אחרי כלב מת אחרי פרעש אחד**, "after a dead dog, after a single flea" (Shmuel I 24:14)	Meaning *like* a dead dog, *like* a flea
The warriors whose **faces were the faces of lions** (Divrei HaYamim I 12:9)	Their faces were *like* lions' faces

A participant expanded on the crucible: you take many pieces of iron, melt them and forge something new. That is why the Exodus took so long. Hashem had to break the people down and purify them. "That's precisely the point he's making," said the Rabbi. He took them out *as if* from a smelting furnace, but the *kaf* is missing.

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2. Quantity

Quantity has two aspects, both impossible for Hashem:

1. **Dimensions**: length, width, depth.
2. **Addition and division**: adding a part to Him or taking one away.

Rav Saadia proves this in three ways:

Proof	Content
Logic	The same rationale as before: dimensions, addition and subtraction are all things Hashem created. He cannot be subject to what He created
Scripture	The warning at Sinai: you saw no image of any kind, so make no form of this or that, and many more verses
Tradition	The **Targumim**

The evidence of the Targum

The Rabbi explained the background. The two main Targumim are **Targum Onkelos**, by the convert Onkelos, around the first century, and **Targum Yonatan ben Uziel**. The Gemara speaks of the Targum's importance, and rules that each week one should read the parasha twice with one translation, the Targum, which was the Aramaic vernacular of the time.

Rav Saadia's point: whenever these Targumim meet a verse that seems to give Hashem physicality, they **change it**. Here, the Rabbi suggested, Rav Saadia is "clearly taking a knock at the Karaites." Our Sages, who are trusted in their interpretation of the Torah, the students of the prophets, consistently steered away from physical readings, from their knowledge of the prophets and from their own reasoning.

Verse	Targum
הנה יד ה׳ הויה במקנך: "the hand of Hashem will be on your cattle"" (Shemot 9:3, the plague of pestilence)	"a **plague from before** Hashem": the hand becomes a plague
ותחת רגליו כמעשה לבנת הספיר: "under His feet was like a sapphire" brick" (Shemot 24:10)	"under His **throne** of glory"
פי ה׳: "the mouth of Hashem"	"the **word** (instruction) of Hashem"
כי בכיתם באזני ה׳: "you wept in the ears of Hashem" (Bamidbar 11:18, from the previous week's parasha)	"**before** Hashem"

A participant objected that Hashem has no chair either. "I understand," said the Rabbi. "The chair also must be understood metaphorically. But the point is they're bothered by the feet, and they're taking it to something that is easier to read metaphorically."

Chapter 10: Ten Bodily Descriptions

Having shown from logic, Scripture and tradition that Hashem has no physical form, Rav Saadia goes through **ten** bodily terms the Tanach uses of Hashem:

#	Organ	Verse
1	**Head**	**וכובע ישועה בראשו**, a helmet of salvation on His head (Yeshayahu 59:17)
2	**Eye**	**עיני ה׳ אלהיך בה**, the eyes of Hashem are always on the land (Devarim 11:12)
3	**Ear**	**כי בכיתם באזני ה׳**, you wept in the ears of Hashem
4	**Mouth**	**כי פי ה׳ דבר**, for the mouth of Hashem has spoken
5	**Lip**	**ומוצא שפתי לא אשנה**, I will not alter what has gone out of My lips (Tehillim 89:35)
6	**Face**	**יאר ה׳ פניו אליך**, Hashem make His face shine on you
7	**Hand**	**יד ה׳**, the hand of Hashem
8	**Heart**	**ויאמר ה׳ אל לבו**, Hashem said to His heart, after the Flood, that He would not destroy again (Bereishit 8:21)
9	**Innards**	**על כן המו מעי לו**, therefore My innards yearn for him, for Ephraim (Yirmiyahu 31:19)
10	**Foot**	**נשתחוה להדום רגליו**, we will bow at His footstool (Tehillim 132:7)

Are these the only ten? Of course not, said the Rabbi. There is the **nose**: the verse about the anger of Hashem "smoking" (**יעשן אף ה׳**). "If you think of those cartoons of the angry man with smoke coming out of his nose, that's what the verse means literally." There is the **outstretched arm**, and many more. "As I've shown you, Saadia loves the number ten. So he just picks ten. That's the only explanation I have."

The richness of language

All of these, says Rav Saadia, must be explained another way. Language **borrows** terms. "That's the beauty, the richness of language."

Verse	Literally
השמים מספרים כבוד אל (Tehillim 19:2)	The heavens speak
וים אמר אין עמדי (Iyov 28:14)	The sea speaks
אבדון ומות אמרו (Iyov 28:22)	Death and destruction speak
The stone that "heard" and will be a witness (Yehoshua 24:27)	Stones hear
The mountains that burst into song	Mountains sing
The hills that gird themselves with joy (Tehillim 65:13)	Hills get dressed

"And many others which it would take me a long time to count." Obviously none of these are meant literally. The heavens "speak" in the sense that looking at them proclaims the glory of God. In the same way the Torah uses language when it speaks about HaKadosh Baruch Hu.

And if you ask why the Torah does not just use plain words and spare us all these chapters, the answer is as before: with only plain language, we could not speak of Hashem hearing, seeing or being compassionate. "All we would have is the existence of Hashem, nothing else to talk about."

What each term means

Rav Saadia then explains the ten:

Term	Meaning	Proof from human usage
Head	Importance, eminence	**כבודי ומרים ראשי**, "my glory, and the One who lifts my head" (Tehillim 3:4): you lift your head to someone important
Eye	Attention, *hashgachah* (providence)	Yosef to the brothers: **ואשימה עיני עליו**, "that I may set my eye on him" (Bereishit 44:21). He did not want literally to put his eye on Binyamin
Face	Anger or favour	Chanah after Eli spoke to her: **ופניה לא היו לה עוד**, "her face was no longer [sad]" (Shmuel I 1:18). The face expresses happiness or sadness
Ear	Listening and accepting	Yehuda to Yosef: **ידבר נא עבדך דבר באזני אדני**, "let your servant speak a word in my lord's ears" (Bereishit 44:18). He did not go up and speak into his ear. It means "please listen"
Mouth, lips	Command, instruction	"By the mouth of Aharon" means his instructions. **שפתי צדיק ירעו רבים**, "the lips of the righteous shepherd many" (Mishlei 10:21): his teachings, not his lips, shepherd
Hand	Ability and capacity	
Heart	Wisdom	Young people who "lack a heart" lack understanding
Innards	Compassion	"My innards yearn for Ephraim": it is deep within Me
Foot	Dominion	"My enemies are under my feet"

Next: The Prophetic Visions

The Rabbi previewed the next question. On Shavuot, a congregant came to him at the end of the first day and asked for his sermon to be on the **Haftarah**, the vision of the **Merkavah**, the chariot, in Yechezkel. "The get-out answer for me was that the Mishnah says you're not meant to study the chariot of Yechezkel in public. The simple answer is, it's too hard for me to teach something like that."

But the question stands. You have told me that "the eye of Hashem" means providence, "the ears of Hashem" means He listens, "His heart" means wisdom. Fine. But how will you explain the **vivid visions of the prophets**, who see chariots, lions and wings? That is for next week.

Summary

1. **Chapter 8:** the most subtle is the strongest. Soul over body, wisdom over soul, water over earth, wind over water. So Hashem's subtlety does not lessen His power: "with wisdom He founded the earth."
2. **The foundational principle:** no substance and no "happening" may be attributed to the Creator, who created all of them. Every such verse must be explained non-physically, and our everyday language about Hashem only borrows terms.
3. **Why the Torah speaks this way:** without such language we could say nothing about Hashem but that He exists.
4. **The ten categories:** substance, quantity, quality, relation, place, time, possession, position, action, being acted upon.
5. **Substance:** not human, fire, air or space, since He created them all. Scripture rules out comparison with all five levels of existence, from gold to angels.
6. **Tzelem Elokim:** for Rav Saadia, a physical form that Hashem singled out with love ("My form," like "My land" and "My mountain"). The classical and Nefesh HaChaim readings make *tzelem* spiritual instead.
7. **"A consuming fire"** means *like* fire. Scripture often drops the *kaf*.
8. **Quantity:** no dimensions, no addition or division, proven by logic, by verse and by the **Targumim**, which consistently turn the physical into the non-physical.
9. **The ten organs** (head, eye, ear, mouth, lip, face, hand, heart, innards, foot) are borrowed language, as when the heavens "speak" and the hills "dress in joy."

"I just love it. It's beautiful to see the way Rav Saadia puts this, the first one putting this forward, how he explains it and how detailed he goes into this, and how important it clearly is to him and to all those that followed him."

Coming Up

- **Next Monday:** the prophetic visions, then the remaining seven categories. The Rabbi hoped to finish Essay 2 within a week or two and move on to Essay 3, "more practical things, and more *chiddush*."
- The Tuesday evening shiur that week was moved to 8.15 to 9.15.

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